

Technology @ home

Have you ever wished you had a door that locked up by itself? A vacuum cleaner that you could control from your office? Well, your wishes are on the verge of coming true

Remember the Jetsons? The family of the future with a goofy dog and a robot maid that your kids catch on Cartoon Network? In the Jetson household, machines seem to do all the working and running. Anything that needs to be done seems just a push of a button away. A sleepy George Jetson makes it to the office every day without lifting a finger, while all the work from bathing and dressing to preparing and serving breakfast is done by their incredibly automated house. For years, writers, moviemakers and cartoonists have fascinated us with the concept of an intelligent home. They shared their vision of the future with us. But which one of these visions are the closest to reality?

2001: Where are we today?

How close are we to intelligent homes, workspaces or devices moving from a stage of novelty to that of universal prevalence? Technological developments that have taken place over the last few years seem to be converging to make an intelligent home possible in the near future. Computing in particular has spawned many of the technologies that are likely to play a major role.

Wireless standards such as CEBus, HomeRF and Bluetooth are making it possible to design devices that communicate with each other without the need for wires. This can be used to provide solutions for many simple automation problems. AMX and Crestron offer control systems that allow you to control any

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